

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Pinnipeds, which include seals, sea lions, and walruses, live in and around water.
- Pinnipeds are descended not from sea animals but from four-legged, land-dwelling carnivores.
- Canadian paleobiologist Natalia Rybczynski recently found a fossil with four legs, webbed toes, and the skull and teeth of a seal.
- Rybczynski refers to her rare find as a “transitional fossil.”
- The fossil illustrates an early stage in the evolution of pinnipeds from their land-dwelling ancestors.

The student wants to emphasize the fossil’s significance. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Canadian paleobiologist Natalia Rybczynski’s fossil has the skull and teeth of a seal, which, like sea lions and walruses, is a pinniped.
- B. Pinnipeds are descended from four-legged, land-dwelling carnivores; a fossil that resembles both was recently found.
- C. Having four legs but the skull and teeth of a seal, the rare fossil illustrates an early stage in the evolution of pinnipeds from their land-dwelling ancestors.
- D. A “transitional fossil” was recently found by paleobiologist Natalia Rybczynski.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence effectively emphasizes the fossil’s significance, explaining that the fossil is rare and illustrates an early stage in the evolution of pinnipeds from their land-dwelling ancestors.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes the fossil Rybczynski found; it doesn’t emphasize the fossil’s significance. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence mentions that a fossil resembling both pinnipeds and their ancestors was found; it doesn’t emphasize the fossil’s significance. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence notes a term used to describe the fossil Rybczynski found; it doesn’t emphasize the fossil’s significance.